Beyond Data: AI for Human Connection

SYNC

# The Modern Fundraising Ops Team

Roles, Skills, and AI Readiness

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StratusLIVE

# Speaker

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# Agenda

- Why this conversation is urgent
- Defining modern fundraising operations
- Roles under transformation
- AI readiness & team skills
- Building the team
- Questions & discussion

# Why this conversation is urgent

## The landscape is shifting fast

- Donor expectations are rising — personalization, speed, seamless giving
- AI tools are proliferating faster than teams can evaluate them
- Many nonprofits are adopting tech without restructuring the teams around it
- The ops team is the connective tissue — get this right and everything else works better

# What is “fundraising operations”?

## A definition that’s still evolving

- Traditional view: CRM admin, gift processing, reporting, compliance
- Modern view: data strategy, donor journey design, systems integration, analytics
- Emerging view: AI governance, prompt engineering, model evaluation, change management
- Ops is no longer back-office — it’s a strategic function

# The four layers of a modern ops team

**01**

## Data & Governance

Data quality, gift processing, compliance, AI oversight

**02**

## Systems & Integration

CRM, payment platforms, email tools, sync architecture

**03**

## Analytics & Insights

Reporting, dashboards, predictive modeling, attribution

**04**

## Donor Experience

Segmentation, personalization, appeals, retention

# The core roles: what’s changing

Five roles under transformation.

# CRM / Data Administrator

- Data entry
- Deduplication
- Basic Configuration

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- Data architecture
- Integration management
- AI-readiness audits

# Analyst / Reporting Lead

- Static reports
- Excel pivot tables
- Manual pulls

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- Self-serve dashboards
- Predictive analytics
- AI-assisted modeling

# Digital Fundraising Manager

- Email campaigns
- Donation page management

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- Omnichannel journeys
- A/B testing
- AI-personalized content at scale

# Operations Director / Manager

- Process documentation
- Vendor management
- Team coordination

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- Technology roadmapping
- AI governance
- Cross-functional alignment

# Data / Prospect Researcher

- Manual wealth screening
- Relationship mapping

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- AI-assisted prospect scoring
- Giving capacity modeling
- Moves management

# The emerging role: AI operations lead

## Not a tech role — a bridge role

- Evaluates and pilots AI tools before org-wide rollout
- Maintains a prompt library and use-case registry for the fundraising team
- Partners with IT/security on data privacy compliance for AI tools
- Trains fundraisers on responsible, effective AI use
- Monitors for AI-generated bias in donor segmentation and scoring
- This role can be dedicated or distributed across an existing team

# AI readiness: where does your team stand?

## 1 Aware

Experimenting with ChatGPT, no formal policy or use-case strategy

## 2 Exploring

Piloting 1–2 AI tools. Staff training ad hoc, no governance framework

## 3 Integrating

AI in 3+ workflows. Documented use-case library, basic governance policy

## 4 Optimizing

AI is part of the operating model. Regular audits, clear ownership, measurable outcomes

A four-stage maturity model

# The skills every ops team member needs now

## Data literacy

- Reading and questioning dashboards
- Understanding data quality and its limits
- Basic statistical reasoning (correlation ≠ causation)

## AI fluency

- Prompting effectively for fundraising tasks
- Recognizing AI output errors and hallucinations
- Understanding what AI can and cannot do with donor data

## Process thinking

- Documenting workflows before automating them
- Identifying bottlenecks vs. tool gaps
- Change management and user adoption

## Ethical judgment

- Donor data privacy and consent
- Equity considerations in predictive scoring
- Transparency with donors about data use

# Building the team

You don’t have to hire your way to maturity

1. Upskill first: identify 1–2 “AI champions” on your existing team and invest in their development
2. Audit before you hire: map current skills against the four-layer model — gaps become job descriptions
3. Structure for collaboration: ops, analytics, and digital must share data and OKRs, not just tools
4. Create psychological safety: teams won’t experiment with AI if they fear being blamed for mistakes
5. Establish a lightweight AI governance committee — doesn’t need to be formal, just accountable
6. Revisit annually: this landscape changes too fast for a static org structure

**6**

Practical pathways to team maturity

# Common pitfalls to avoid

## What well-intentioned teams get wrong

- Buying AI tools without asking “who will own this workflow?”
- Treating AI readiness as an IT problem rather than a team culture problem
- Skipping the data quality work — AI amplifies bad data, it doesn’t fix it
- Measuring AI success only by cost savings, not donor experience or staff capacity
- Forgetting that your donors are people — not data points to be optimized

# The team you're building toward

## A north star, not a destination

- Small but mighty: 3–5 people can run a high-performing ops function with the right tools and skills
- Deeply collaborative: no longer siloed from programs, major gifts, or communications
- Perpetually curious: treats every new tool as a hypothesis to test, not a solution to deploy
- Grounded in mission: technology serves the cause — not the other way around
- The best ops teams make the fundraisers around them dramatically more effective

# Questions & discussion

**01**

Where does your org sit on the maturity model — and what's holding you back from the next stage?

**02**

Which of the five roles is most underdeveloped on your team right now?

**03**

What's one AI use case you've been curious about but haven't piloted yet?

**04**

How is your organization thinking about donor data privacy as you adopt AI tools?

Let's dig into what matters most to your team

# Keep the momentum going

### The Right Donor, Right Now
Today, 3:15 PM
John Funari & Lori Combs

AI-assisted prospecting and data signals.

### Making Reports Useful Again
Today, 3:15 PM
Paula Elrod

From dashboards to real decisions.

### AI 101: Prompt Engineering
Tomorrow, 3:00 PM
Brett Meyer

Nonprofit AI use cases and keeping donor data safe.

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